Over the next few weeks her ditz-act began to fray at the edges; when he looked out her window and observed, "Kid, it's gonna rain," she responded, "Apparently so," raising her eyebrows and smiling at him. Then, in the train station, when he said the candy guy looked like a Neanderthal, she came out with the incredible: "Well, don't knock them, they buried their dead with flowers and the archaeologists found petrified pollen all over the place."

Miro wheeled on her with a look of naked amazement. "You're into the Paleolithic period?" The traffic in the station streamed past them, and a lady let her heavy bag knock Miro's leg, but he barely noticed, absorbed in Doreen's smile.

"I wouldn't say I'm into it, but I like to read about it. It's *interesting*."

That afternoon they made love like wild animals, and Miro felt closer to Doreen than he had ever felt to any girl before. But when he sat on the edge of the bed with a cigarette, caressing Doreen's socked foot and letting his eyes drift around the room, he noticed how many books on Early Man he'd accumulated, and how prominently they were placed, on the window sills and the eye-level bookshelves; and then he noticed that *Neanderthal and His World* was missing.

It was either womanly or girlish, he couldn't decide, that Doreen would affect interests she didn't really have in an effort to get closer to him. It was deceptive, sure, but it had certainly closed the sale that afternoon in the train station. And couldn't that be forgiven? Watching her put on makeup before they went out to dinner that night, he knew she had the same feeling he always got when a new lie would suddenly insert itself into his pitch, when aluminum became titanium, or a warranty suddenly shrank three years and sprouted extra fees: *this is no joke, this is survival.* Look at her: painting an inch thick, to keep me. That he and Doreen were both the same in this, both liars and sellers, made him want her more than her makeup ever could. But he felt awful about it. Love was supposed to be the one area where you didn't push and pull so hard, you let it happen by itself. Lies, no matter how white, were for work; and what did that make Doreen?

At his feet lay an archipelago of toothed wheels that seemed to have once been the guts of a gearbox. Off to their left a rod, maybe the stick shift, was stuck flat in the dirt; a spider had included it in its web.

And here was the shed. The door had fallen off, but the sun was behind it now and he stood on the threshold in the dark, waiting for his eyes to adjust. When they did, he saw that the whole cobwebbed room was taken up by an enormous machine, whose heavy black parts were of that same cast iron as the littered fragments strewn

about the field. In fact, he gathered, it was the same machine; but here the pieces all fit together, into a harvester of some kind, pre-war, American, abandoned. He stood and stared at it for what seemed like a whole hour in a deep dream of rest. The old machine filled him with remorse and sadness, filled him with an ancient loneliness he had been running from, he knew, all his life. Before his mind there passed the faces and figures of customer after customer, faces he thought he had forgotten forever: short men and tall ones and fat fathers whom he had more or less swindled with their sweet adolescent sons watching through the window, draped on the car across the street. He saw the salesmen who couldn't close, Turner and Levy and nervous Cohen and the transient losers who quit after two weeks; he saw Rhoda, and Doreen, and the lady with the heavy bag in the train station. And looking on this gigantic secret dinosaur, intact in its desiccated shed, he saw them all as Neanderthals, and himself among them, all sleeping together in the dark of a cave, all covered in furs, all finally together and all deeply and silently sleeping.